

Lesson 6: Fairways and Forest Fires

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We've all heard it said before, it's not just about what you say, but also how you say it. This is just as true in the workplace as it is anywhere else. Understanding the importance of situational and nonverbal communication can make a significant difference in developing a positive and productive team. And it all starts with you as the leader.

Before we dive into the nitty-gritty, let's take a moment to understand the power of tone in communication. Tone refers to the emotional quality behind the words we use, whether in spoken or written form. It conveys our attitudes, emotions, and intentions impacting how our messages are received by others.

Suppose you came up to a colleague after a presentation where they dropped their coffee on their notes. That didn't go well, you joke, smiling. Suppose you came up to the same colleague afterwards with a stern look on your face. That didn't go well, you announce in a serious, somewhat ominous tone.

In the workplace, context matters. We need to be mindful of the situations we find ourselves in and tailor our communication accordingly. Take a team meeting, for instance. An overly aggressive tone might shut down ideas and squash your team's feedback. On the other hand, if a team member has been making inappropriate comments or getting out of hand, a firm tone may be entirely appropriate.

In a one-on-one with your team members especially, it's essential to strike a balance between being supportive and providing constructive feedback. A dismissive tone can make the employee feel unimportant, while a caring and constructive tone can inspire growth. Feedback given in a harsh tone can be taken much differently than feedback in a positive tone.

In general, there are four quadrants of vocal variety:

Loud and slow conveys authority. You might use this when addressing an issue that is critical and there needs to be no room for misunderstanding.

Loud and fast communicates enthusiasm. You might use this when you are introducing a new idea in a meeting and you need to generate excitement.

Low and slow communicates sincerity and empathy. This tone you might use when you're consoling a team member or delivering difficult news.

Soft and fast conveys anticipation. You might use this tone to communicate upcoming changes, almost as if you are letting someone in on a secret.

Knowing how and when to use different tones appropriately can be the difference between coming off as authoritative or weak, sensitive or insensitive, excited or unenthusiastic.

Remember, our words are just one part of the message we convey. Research suggests that up to 93% of communication is nonverbal. That means that our body language, facial expressions, and tone of voice play a big part in how our messages are interpreted.

So, how can we be a part of creating a positive communication culture in the workplace? Self-awareness is the first step in becoming effective communicators. With that in mind, let's dive in.